

# Pablo Álvarez-Aragón

<https://www.pabloalvarezaragon.com>

## Contact Information

pablo.alvarez@unamur.be

8 rempart de la Vierge, B5000 Namur

## Personal Information

Citizenship: Spanish

Born in 1997

---

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

**Primary:** Development Economics

**Secondary:** Economic History, family economics, Economics of Religion

---

## REFERENCES

### Catherine Guirkinge

Full Professor of Economics

University of Namur

catherine.guirkinge@unamur.be

### Jean-Philippe Platteau

Emeritus Professor of Economics

University of Namur

jean-philippe.platteau@unamur.be

### Jean-Marie Baland

Full Professor of Economics

University of Namur

jean-marie.baland@unamur.be

---

## DOCTORAL STUDIES

**2021-2025, University of Namur (CRED)**

Ph.D Development Economics

Advisor: Catherine Guirkinge

Dissertation jury: Jean-Marie Baland, Augustin Bergeron, Pauline Rossi

**September 2023 - March 2024, Paris School of Economics**

Visiting Scholar

Supervisor: Denis Cogneau

**March 2025, Vancouver School of Economics**

Visiting Scholar

Supervisors: Siwan Anderson and Nathan Nunn

---

## PRE-DOCTORAL STUDIES

**2019-2021 - MSc in Economics, UCLouvain. *Summa Cum Laude***

2015–2019 – BA in Economics, University of Valladolid.

2016–2019 – BA in Economics, University of Lille.

---

## RESEARCH WORK

*(Abstracts are in the last page)*

### Working Papers

- **Paths to the Rainforests: Ancestral Beliefs and Fertility in Sub-Saharan Africa**
- **School Clustering and Religious Competition: Persistence of Educational Inequality in Colonial and Post-Colonial D.R. Congo**  
(With P. Villar and C. Guirkingner)  
*Submitted*
- **Measuring Norms and Enumerator Effects: Survey Method Matters**  
(With H. Champeaux)  
*Revise and Resubmit, The World Bank Economic Review*  
AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0011696
- **Kinship Structure and Fertility**  
(With L. Angelini and A. Jolivet)  
*Draft available upon request*

### Work in Progress

- Shaking the Traditional Order: Female New Christian Converts as Engine of Change in Sub-Saharan Africa  
(With J-P. Platteau and C. Guirkingner)
- Husbands in the Room: The Impact of Joint vs. Women-Only Training on Household Dynamics in Benin  
(With C. Guirkingner, A. Jolivet and A. Lulle)  
AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0008898
- Robustness and Replicability in Development Economics  
(PI: Jorg Ankel-Peters, co-PI: Anna Dreber and Magnus Johannesson)

### Other writings

- Álvarez-Aragón, P., Baland, J.M., Guirkingner, C., Villar, P. (2025). "L'héritage des Soeurs Catholiques Missionnaires : Effets sur le Capital Humain des Femmes en République Démocratique du Congo". *Revue d'Économie du Développement*, *forthcoming*.
- Álvarez-Aragón, P. (2022). "Lucas Chancel; Unsustainable Inequalities: Social Justice and the Environment". *Revista Papeles de Relaciones Ecosociales y Cambio Global*.

- Álvarez-Aragón, P. (2021). "Sobre Los Premios Nobel De Economía". Revista De Economía Crítica, n. 32 (diciembre):2-9.
- Álvarez-Aragón, P. (2021). "Slobodian, Quinn; Globalists. The End of Empire and the Birth of Neoliberalism". Revista De Economía Crítica, n. 28 (junio):154-57.

---

## TEACHING AND RELEVANT ACTIVITIES

### Teaching

- **2022** – Applied Econometrics (graduate), University of Namur  
Teaching Assistant to Prof. Wouter Gelade, National Bank of Belgium (12h)  
Contents: Linear regression, Non-linear models, Panel data, Experimental and quasi-experimental methods
- **2024** – Economic Tools to Solve Global Challenges (graduate), UCLouvain and U. Namur  
Teaching Assistant to Prof. Guilhem Cassan, University of Namur and to Prof. Amma Panin (UCLouvain)  
Contents: Replication, causal inference

### International experience

- **2020-2021** – Research Assistant to Marcus Biermann, Bielefeld University
- **2018-2019** – Research Assistant to Oscar Carpintero, University of Valladolid

### Fieldwork and data entry

- **2025** – Data collection and supervision, Benin (x2)
- **2024** – Data collection and supervision, Benin (x2)
- **2023** – Data collection and supervision, Benin
- **2022** – RA supervision to digitize historical documents
- **2021** – Data collection and supervision, Benin

---

## SEMINARS AND CONFERENCES

**2024-2025** – Pontificia Universidad Javeriana\*; ASREC Conference, University of Macedonia; CRED Workshop, UNamur; Job Market Training, CERDI; II Spanish Workshop in Development Economics, Navarra Center for International Development, IRES Lunch seminar, UCLouvain; Doctoral Workshop UCLouvain, Namur, USaint Louis (x2); Vodoun School of Economics, Ouidah; CSAE 2025 Conference, Oxford University; AFEPOP 2025, Aix-Marseille School of Economics\*; 4th Workshop in Gender and Economics, University of Luxembourg\*; Workshop on Cultural Transmission and Persistence, Queen's University Belfast (Scheduled); International Conference in Development Economics (ICDE), Paris Nanterre University (Scheduled)

**2023–2024** – LAGV\*; International Conference in Development Economics (ICDE), Aix Marseille School of Economics, DIAL\*; University of Santiago de Compostela, AFEPOP2024, EHES; Bolzano Historical Economics Workshop\*, EUDN Bocconi\*, Casual Friday Development Seminar, Paris School of Economics; Sassari\*; Cagliari\*; Annual Conference of the Spanish Economic Association, University of Salamanca; CERDI\*; Atelier Simiand, Paris School of Economics; UCLouvain, UNamur and U. Saint Louis Doctoral Workshop (x2); Institutions, Culture, and Long-Term Development: Lessons from sub-Saharan Africa Conference, CRED; Center for Research in the Economics of Development (CRED) Workshop, UNamur; Development Economics Workshop, Universitat de Barcelona School of Economics; ENS Lyon Applied Seminar\*

**2022–2023** – International Conference on Development Economics (ICDE), Paris School of Economics\*; Bordeaux School of Economics Internal Seminar\*; University of Valladolid Internal Seminar; ASREC Conference, Harvard University; UCLouvain, UNamur and U. Saint Louis Doctoral Workshop; PARSC Conference, African School of Economics; Center for Research in the Economics of Development (CRED) Workshop, UNamur

**2021–2022** – University of Castilla-La-Mancha; Workshop in Gender and Family Economics, CY Cergy Paris University\*; CRED Workshop, UNamur; UCLouvain, UNamur and U. Saint Louis Doctoral Workshop

\* Presented by a co-author

---

## FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

**2025:** Scientific Stay Grant – Special Research Fund (FSR)

**2024:** Robustness and Replicability in Economics (R2E) – German Science Foundation (DFG) Priority Programme Meta-Rep

**2023:** Scientific Stay Grant (FSR-FNRS)

**2023–2025:** Doctoral fellowship – Fonds National de la Recherche Scientifique (FNRS)

**2022–2023:** Doctoral fellowship – Special Research Fund (FSR)

**2021–2022:** Doctoral fellowship – European Research Council, H2020/ERC – StG 759294

**2018–2019:** Collaboration Fellowship – MINECO, Spanish Government

**2017–2018:** Erasmus+ Mobility Scholarship – European Union

---

## TECHNICAL STRENGTHS AND LANGUAGES

**Languages:** Spanish (Native), English (Fluent), French (Advanced)

**Software & Tools:** Stata, SurveyCTO, QGIS,  $\text{\LaTeX}$ , KoboToolBox, MS Office

---

## REFEREEING

Review of Development Economics (x2)

---

## OTHER ACTIVITIES

**2023** – Organizer Doctoral Workshop in Economics – UNamur, UCLouvain and USaint-Louis

**2019** – Editor of the Blog ["Puntos de Encuentro"](#), jointly with scholars and students from the University of Valladolid.

### **Paths to the Rainforests: Ancestral Beliefs and Fertility in sub-Saharan Africa**

This paper provides insights into the determinants of fertility collapse by examining the demographic consequences of traditional religious beliefs in sub-Saharan Africa. I focus on the impact of a belief system that emphasizes the role of ancestors, who have a strong interest in the continuation of their lineage into which they may be reincarnated. I combine first-hand data, novel ethnographic information and historical and contemporary surveys to show: 1) a strong, positive relationship between ancestral beliefs and fertility across contexts and time periods; and 2) that this relationship is specifically driven by the motive to continue one's lineage. Guided by a simple model where the total number of children in the lineage is a public good and depends on the kinship system, I show that 1) the effect of ancestral beliefs is driven by patrilineal societies, where the motive to continue one's lineage is stronger; and 2) in groups with ancestral beliefs, there is free rider behavior among siblings: In patrilineal societies, fertility decreases with the number of the husband's brothers, whereas in matrilineal societies, female fertility decreases with the number of sisters (but not brothers). These predictions are supported by the data.

### **School Clustering and Religious Competition: Persistence of Educational Inequality in Colonial and Post-Colonial Congo**

*(With Catherine Guirkingner and Paola Villar)*

This paper examines the persistence of educational inequalities in Africa, focusing on colonial and contemporary Congo. By analyzing historical and contemporary surveys, archives, and school administrative data, we document the continuing impact of colonial-era factors and explore mechanisms of path dependency. We find that contemporary educational inequalities are driven by the clustering of post-independence schools around historical colonial schools. This clustering dynamic has increased over time and is shaped by religious competition between schools of different denominations. This spatial pattern significantly affects girls' education more than boys' because girls are more sensitive to distance barriers, explaining a stronger colonial legacy for female education. Our analysis suggests that parental education and missions as agents of structural change have limited influence on regional educational outcomes in this context.

### **Measuring Norms and Enumerator Effects: Survey Method Matters**

*(With Hugues Champeaux)*

While the process of data collection can lead to bias, little empirical evidence investigates the role of the survey method. In this paper, we compare two survey methods: the standard face-to-face interview and an alternative method we call Human-Assisted Self-Administered survey (HASA). In the latter, respondents are guided by an enumerator reading questions, but they answer privately on an electronic device. Taking advantage of an RCT in Benin, we randomize the survey method across respondents while holding the questionnaire constant. We show that the survey method leads to different results depending on the degree of enumerator influence. Identifying this influence by quantifying how much of the variation in the outcome variable is attributable to enumerators, we document that variables that are unlikely to be influenced by enumerators do not differ significantly across survey methods. However, variables that are likely to be affected differ systematically. These variables are mainly related to norms, opinions, and beliefs. In particular, we find that respondents who answer

directly on an electronic device report less gender-equal behavior and values. Investigating the mechanisms, we show that social desirability bias is more likely to affect responses in classical face-to-face interviews, where individuals' responses are less confidential.

### **Kinship Structure and Fertility**

*(With L. Angelini and A. Jolivet)*

We examine the relationship between the social organization of communities – their emphasis on unilineal descent – and fertility. In unilineal societies, descent is traced primarily through either the mother's or the father's side, which strongly determines social identity, increases cohesion, and reinforces interdependence within the lineage. Numerous children are valued as reinforcing the position of a continuous lineage, conferring strength and prestige on its members. We show that, across countries, unilineal societies have higher fertility levels and experience slower fertility decline. These results are validated within sub-Saharan Africa using a spatial regression discontinuity design along ancestral ethnic boundaries. Moreover, we show that the positive influence of unilineal descent on fertility is driven by patrilineal ethnic groups. In terms of mechanisms, we find suggestive evidence that the stronger motive to continue one's lineage, higher marital stability, the prevalence of extended households and polygyny, and the lower bargaining power of women in patrilineal societies drive fertility upwards.